

PRACTICAL TEST AUTOMATION WITH PLAYWRIGHT

Playwright Config Reference

The settings in playwright.config.ts that matter most.

Introduction

The config file controls how your whole suite runs. Understanding the key options lets you make tests faster, more reliable and easier to debug. This reference covers the settings you will actually touch.

Key Options

Option	What it does
testDir	Where your tests live
use.baseUrl	Base for page.goto('/path')
use.trace	Capture traces (e.g. 'on-first-retry')
use.screenshot / video	Capture on failure
retries	Re-run failed tests (useful in CI)
workers	Parallelism
projects	Run across browsers/devices
reporter	Output format (html, list, etc.)

Worked Example (sensible defaults)

- use: { baseUrl: 'https://app.example.com', trace: 'on-first-retry', screenshot: 'only-on-failure' }
- retries: process.env.CI ? 2 : 0
- reporter: 'html'
- projects: [{ name: 'chromium' }, { name: 'firefox' }, { name: 'webkit' }]

Practical Exercise

Set a baseUrl and switch your tests to relative paths. Enable trace on-first-retry and confirm a trace is produced when a test is retried.

Best Practices

- Use baseUrl so tests are environment-portable.
- Enable traces/screenshots on failure for fast debugging.
- Use retries in CI, not locally.

Common Mistakes

- Hard-coding full URLs everywhere.
- High retries hiding genuinely flaky tests.
- No artefacts captured on failure, so CI failures are hard to diagnose.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Set retries in CI but keep them at 0 locally. Retries mask flakiness — you want to see and fix it on your machine, not paper over it in the pipeline.